

FOUR BLOCK APPROACH AND ORAL LANGUAGE DEVELOPMENT



Notes

- 3.1. *Introduction*
- 3.2. *Learning Outcomes*
- 3.3. *Understanding the Four Blocks of Language Learning (NCF-FS & NCF-SE)*
- 3.4. *Oral Language Development in L2*
- 3.5. *Listening and Speaking: Foundation for Oral Language Development in L2*
- 3.6. *Inclusive Classroom Practices for Oral Language Development*
- 3.7. *Let Us Sum Up*
- 3.8. *End Exercises*
- 3.9. *References*

3.1 INTRODUCTION

Language is the foundation upon which literacy and communication skills are built. It is central to all learning. The National Curriculum Framework for the Foundational Stage (NCF-FS, 2022) advocates that children learn better and at ease when they are encouraged to use language in a positive and supportive environment.

In Indian multilingual classrooms, especially in the context of primary education, developing oral language in a second language (L2) requires intentional, inclusive, and context-sensitive pedagogical approaches. Thus, in multilingual India, it is imperative that a second language should not be imposed but rather be introduced gradually through meaningful oral interaction.

For learners in early grades, especially in rural or under-resourced settings, L2 may be an unfamiliar language. Hence, the role of the teacher becomes pivotal in providing rich oral input through various methods like conversation,

Pedagogy and
Resources

Notes

storytelling, picture description, etc. These methods, when aligned with the Four-Block Approach, make language learning a meaningful, enjoyable, and effective process.

This unit aims to equip in-service primary teachers with the knowledge and practical tools to apply the Four-Block Approach in their Language II classrooms, fostering oral language development as a stepping stone towards learning a second language. In most schools in India, English is being taught as a second language. Thus, in this unit, the discussion will revolve around English as a second language.

**3.2 LEARNING OUTCOMES**

After completion of this chapter, the learner:

- Explains the four-block approach and its role in language development;
- Describes the link between oral language and literacy, focusing on listening and speaking as foundational skills;
- Recognises the role and importance of listening in oral expression;
- Plans include inclusive, integrated activities encouraging participation across diverse language backgrounds.

3.3. UNDERSTANDING THE FOUR BLOCKS OF LANGUAGE LEARNING (NCF-FS & NCF-SE)

The National Curriculum Framework for the Foundational Stage (NCF-FS, 2022) and the National Curriculum Framework for School Education (NCF-SE, 2023) advocate for an integrated, developmental approach to language learning. They emphasise that a child's language learning journey should begin with their context and using language naturally. In the case of a second language (L2), this becomes more important and essential as they may have very limited or no exposure to it outside of school. According to the NCF-FS (2022), "There are four major components in language and literacy instruction—oral language, word recognition, reading, and writing" (p. 116), which are termed the Four Block Approach. It offers a practical and flexible structure for language learning and scaffolds second language learning in a meaningful and child-friendly manner. The Four Block Model comprises:

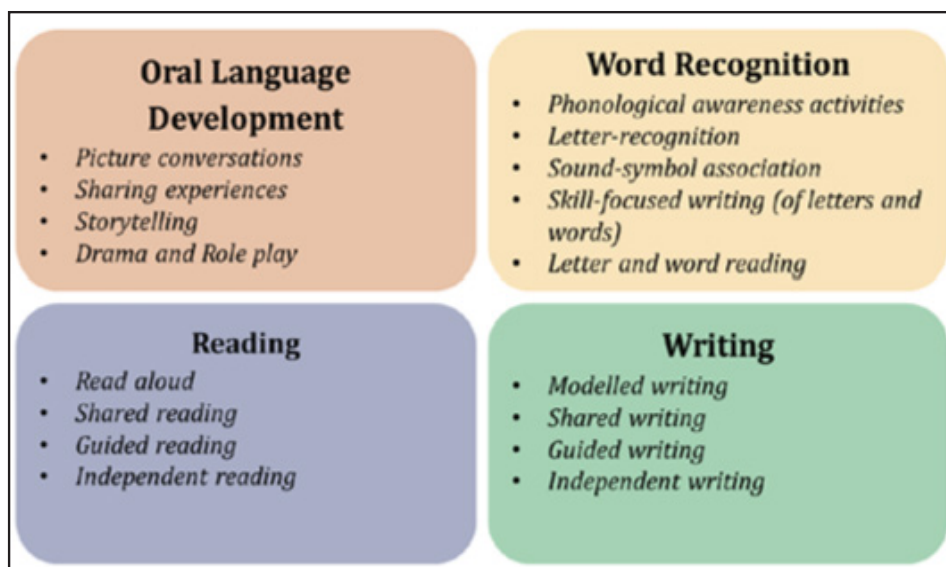


Fig. 3.1: Four Block Model by NCF-FS (2022, p. 116)

These blocks are not sequential but interrelated. They form a comprehensive model of balanced literacy where all blocks may be implemented in an integrated manner, but it is also important that children spend time working on each block regularly. Let's discuss each block in detail.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 3.1

1. What are the four major components of language and literacy instruction as per NCF-FS?
2. The four-block approach offers a structure of language learning which is not:
 - a. meaningful
 - b. child-friendly
 - c. rigid
 - d. practical
3. The blocks are not sequential but _____.

Answers:

2. b). rigid
3. interrelated



3.3.1. Oral Language Development

Children learn language by listening and speaking before they learn to read and write. Before entering school, they are already equipped with the vocabulary from their immediate environment. Hence, it becomes imperative that they are given ample exposure to the target language, which includes both listening and speaking in the said language. This becomes more important in the case of L2 as they already have little to no exposure to the language in their immediate environment. It is necessary that they are immersed in the rich oral experiences to become comfortable with the sounds, rhythm, vocabulary, and sentence patterns of L2. This leads to improved listening comprehension, oral vocabulary development, and using talk and conversation for learning.

As per NCF-FS (2022), oral language development comprises the following components:

1. **Picture Conversations:** Includes discussions, talks, etc. on pictures, posters. Children are encouraged to share their observations and thoughts, ask questions, and listen and respond to peers and others.
2. **Sharing Experiences:** Provides opportunities for children to talk, and encourages them to share their experiences, feelings, and ideas without fear or judgement in a comfortable environment.
3. **Storytelling:** Stories are a good medium for learning about social relationships, ethical choices, emotions, and life skills; acquaint them with their culture and social norms; and create awareness about their surroundings. Listening to stories helps children learn new words and problem-solving skills. Apart from listening to stories, children also need to be given the opportunity to tell/narrate stories.
4. **Drama and Role play:** Drama and Role play cultivate vocabulary acquisition within meaningful contexts and boost communication, confidence, expression, and fluency. They refine both verbal and non-verbal communication skills, thus fostering a comprehensive linguistic competence. The plot and characters also provide the learners with the opportunity where they empathise with the characters. This helps them in the resolution of conflicts.

Some classroom practices for oral language development are: picture talk and description, conversation (free and guided), discussions, asking and answering

questions, singing rhymes, chants, and songs, reading aloud to children, playing games, engaging in drama, role play and dialogue, storytelling with visuals and gestures, read-along stories, and greetings.

NEP 2020 highlights that language should be taught in an interactive way; thus, teachers should not focus on correctness in the beginning, but on engagement and participation.

3.3.2. Word Recognition

Word recognition in language learning refers to the ability of young children to identify and comprehend individual words visually, auditorily, or through other sensory cues (2024, *Teachers' Handbook Class 1-2*, NCERT, p.29). It also involves being able to read words accurately and fluently. In L2, children begin by associating spoken language with print. This involves phonemic awareness, letter-sound association, and decoding in L2. Word recognition lays the future groundwork for reading and language acquisition. It includes the following components:

- 1. Phonological awareness activities:** It is the understanding of the sound structure of language. It includes the child's ability to manipulate and classify each speech sound or phoneme by listening or seeing it. This later helps them in recognising and articulating the spoken parts of sentences and words.
- 2. Letter recognition:** It involves child's ability to identify and differentiate individual letters of the alphabet, i.e. being able to say the name of the letter when they see it (e.g., 'B'), being able to distinguish between letter shapes (e.g., 'B' and 'b' or 'b' and 'd') and knowing how to form the letters.
- 3. Sound-symbol association:** It is the fundamental understanding that there is a systematic association between the sounds we speak (phonemes) and the written symbols (graphemes or alphabets) that represent them. Example: /a/ in 'apple' is associated with letter 'a'.
- 4. Skill-focused writing (of letters and words):** It aims at developing children's foundational writing mechanics and accuracy like, letter formation, developing fine motor skills necessary for writing, letter spacing, and alignment within a word and sentence, etc.
- 5. Letter and word reading:** It lays the fundamental pillars to engage with written language. It represents the transition from oral language to active



Notes

Pedagogy and
Resources

Notes

reading and writing. This includes letter recognition, phonics, identifying and pronouncing words- decoding, sight word recognition (*the, and, is, are etc.*)

Some classroom practices for word recognition are: calling out a letter shown or picking out a letter in a group of letters using flash cards, counting or separating words or syllables, rhyming words, blending and segmenting of words (e.g., Monkey is broken into 'Mon' and 'Key'), identify words with the same sound, reading aloud sight words, word walls etc.

3.3.3. Reading

Once children learn to recognise words, the next step for them is to derive meaning from the texts. Reading in L2 should not be limited to decoding alone; constructing meaning from the written text and critically thinking about it while relating and enjoying what they have read is also a part of reading. Reading skill in a child is developed in a phased manner. In the context of L2, it is important that what they are reading is linked to their context and environment, making it easier for them to relate and understand the text. The components of reading are:

- 1. Read-aloud:** It is a teaching strategy where the teachers or caregivers read books aloud to the children. This activity acts as a model of reading for children. It helps them in fluent reading, pronunciation, and improving their listening skills. This promotes comprehension, understanding of the text. This also allows them to understand how the language sounds when it is read, along with voice modulation and expression. Discussions and conversations make up an essential part of this activity, where children engage with text and pictures.
- 2. Shared reading:** It is an instructional approach where the teacher and the children together read the same text. The teacher reads the text aloud, and children, when they recognise a word (sight word or from memory) or by predicting through an illustration, may join the reading. This helps in developing the concept of print among children and helps them progress beyond their current level and become confident readers.
- 3. Guided Reading:** At this level, the responsibility of reading shifts from the teacher to the children. Here, the children take the lead in their reading, and the teacher provides support as needed. They are introduced to texts appropriate for their age and reading proficiency.



4. Independent Reading: In this practice, children read independently without direct support or guidance from the teacher. They select books independently as per their interests and read them alone or with a partner. This helps in developing the habit of silent reading. They begin to read for themselves, begin to value the act of reading, and reflect on the experience or joy of reading a book.

Some of the key classroom practices for reading are: reading aloud big picture books, reading in a circle, reading groups/pairs, predicting story endings, answering “who, what, where” questions, and translating local stories into other languages with the children.

It is important for teachers to remember that children start reading the moment they start interacting with the print available in their surroundings. This means they start learning to read before entering the formal process of reading. They engage with texts through visual cues and repeated interaction. Thus, it is important to take into account their previous knowledge and build upon it.

3.3.4. Writing

NCF-FS (2022) defines writing as the “[a]bility to write words correctly, along with presentation of thoughts or information in a logical and organised manner” (p. 114). Krishna Kumar (1992) said, “Writing is a kind of talk. As we write, we communicate with someone although most often the person we are communicating with is not present in front of us.” (p. 33). When children start writing, it provides them with an opportunity to express themselves. They are eager to share what they have seen, heard, felt, said, and read. It is important that, apart from their mother tongue or first language, children also learn to express themselves in a second language to reach a larger audience. Moreover, the writing task in L2 should naturally emerge from their oral and reading experiences, ensuring a meaningful and connected learning process. The components of writing are:

- 1. Modelled Writing:** In this instructional strategy, the teacher demonstrates the writing process by writing collaboratively with the children. These are the children who are learning to write. Example: The teacher can ask the child what they have scribbled or drawn, and then write below or beside it. This helps them learn the conventions of print.
- 2. Shared Writing:** It is a collaborative writing activity where both the teacher and the children work together to write a text. Children gain knowledge of

Pedagogy and
Resources

Notes

writing due to continuous exposure to print in various forms, like making lists, attendance, charts, etc. For example, teacher can write a sentence on board, “I ate _____ for breakfast” and ask the children to complete the sentences with their responses. Here, the teacher continuously models, prompts, and guides the children in the writing process.

3. **Guided Writing:** It involves providing support and guidance to young children as they engage in the writing process. Here, the responsibility shifts on the child from the teacher. The teacher supports by giving feedback, suggestions, and prompts to maintain the flow of writing. Peer collaboration can be encouraged in the form of feedback to each other, working in pairs or groups, and revising their writings accordingly.
4. **Independent Writing:** In this process, children are encouraged and given time to write individually or independently without direct guidance or supervision. This encourages them to be creative and imaginative as they engage in the functional aspects of literacy. As a result, they create poems, stories, and messages on their own.

Some of the classroom practices to encourage writing are: drawing and labelling objects, writing simple sentences on topics related to them like ‘family’ or ‘school’, completing sentence prompts, writing or rewriting stories based on pictures, drawing maps of familiar places and labelling them, listing sounds, etc.

In the context of L2, emergent writers should be encouraged to express freely, with more focus on ideas than on grammar or spelling at early stages.

3.3.5 Integration of the Blocks

As mentioned earlier, it is important to remember that all the blocks are interrelated and are not sequential. Each block reinforces the others. Even though all the blocks are different, they cannot be transacted independently but occur simultaneously, with one block being more dominant than the others. For example, a storytelling session (oral language) can lead to drawing scenes from the story (writing), identifying key vocabulary (word recognition), and answering questions about it (comprehension). Integrating blocks creates a dynamic, supportive environment where language is not taught in isolation but as a tool for meaning-making.

Let us take a look at the following activity conducted by the teacher in the 2nd grade classroom for L2 learning to get a better understanding.

The teacher displays a picture of a Haat in her class (Fig. 3.2). She then asks the children to observe the picture carefully and gives them some time. Then, she starts bringing attention to certain details by asking them questions in L2.

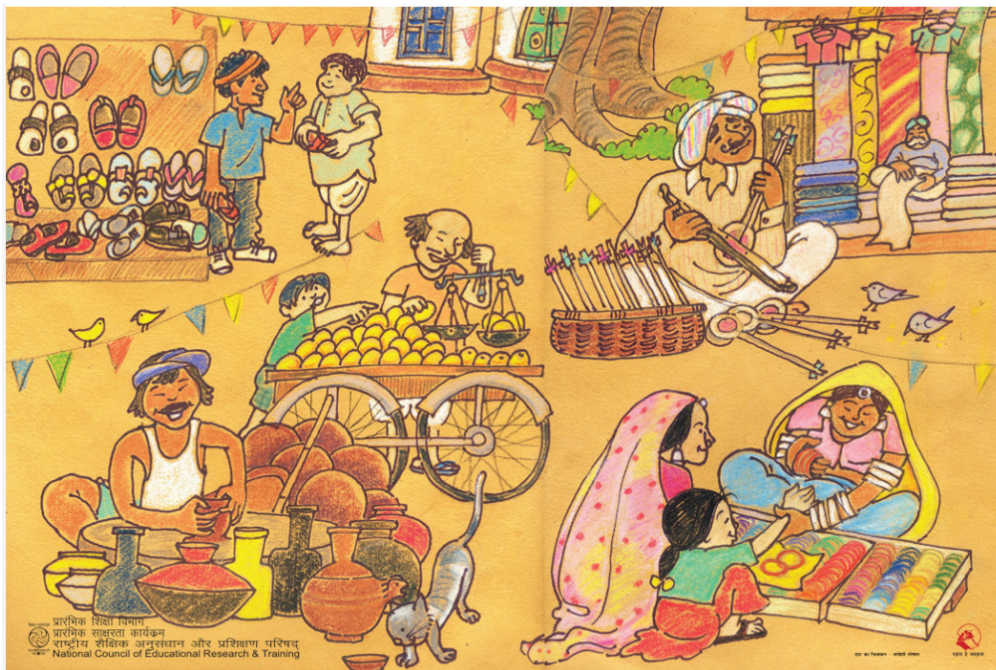


Fig 3.2 : Haat (Website poster, NCERT)

Some questions are:

1. What is this picture of?
2. Have they seen a similar situation in their area?
3. Who are the different people they see in the picture?
4. What is the person who sells fruits called?
5. What does a cobbler sell?

Then, she takes the activity to the next step and asks the children to make a list of animals and birds that they can see in the picture. She also asks them to write down the names of the colours of the bangles.

During the activity, children also started sharing their experiences of visiting a Haat in their area, all the things they saw, and the different activities and people they encountered.



Notes

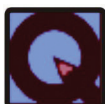


Notes

The next day, the teacher again showed them the same poster and asked them to enact the scene and conversation between:

1. The girl and the bangle seller
2. The cobbler and the customer

The teacher different students to come to the front and enact the scene of their choice.

**CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 3.2**

1. What types of activities can be used to develop oral language development in Language 2?
2. Why is it important to integrate all four blocks in classroom teaching?

3.4 ORAL LANGUAGE DEVELOPMENT IN L2

Language learning begins with oral language. Here, oral language and talk include both listening and speaking skills. They listen, observe, reflect, and respond to the things and situations around them. Oral language serves as the bedrock for second language (L2) development. It acts as a bridge between the learner's known world and the unfamiliar sounds and structures of the second language.

The role played by oral language in L2 development is multifaceted as it impacts all other language skills. Oral language development in L2 is important because it lays the foundation for literacy development in L2, fosters direct communication, and helps in vocabulary and grammar acquisition. It is important to remember that oral language does not precede reading and writing in terms of skill but shapes and strengthens them. It has been highlighted in the NCF-FS (2022) that a child's language journey begins with listening to and reproducing language in a meaningful context. It is important that L2 is introduced through rich, contextual oral language experiences to children who have limited exposure to the new language in their environment.

3.4.1. Why Oral Language Matters in L2 Learning

Oral language serves several critical functions in the acquisition of a Second Language (L2):



1. Builds familiarity with the sound system and rhythm of the language:

Children need to be immersed in the L2 in the classroom and hear it repeatedly in natural, conversational settings to internalise the structures of the language and learn it meaningfully. It is important to ensure that meaning-making is always the core of language learning, but at the same time, pronunciation, intonation, and the basic grammatical structures of the language are also internalised by the learner. This can be done through instructions, responses, chants, songs, and rhymes by the teacher.

2. Develops vocabulary through context: Hearing words and sentences in the L2 in meaningful contexts (e.g., “Pass me the green colour”, “Everybody stand up for the National Anthem”) helps children understand and remember new vocabulary more easily than through rote memorisation methods.

3. Lowers the fear and anxiety and encourages students: Hearing L2 regularly in meaningful contexts helps children reduce the fear and anxiety related to the language. They often feel anxious when asked to read or write in L2. Regular oral interactions through games, storytelling, group conversations, switching between L1 and L2 by the teacher, not focusing on grammar and sentence structure when a child speaks, can help reduce fear and increase engagement.

4. Enables real-time thinking and expression: Oral activities allow immediate feedback and spontaneous use of language, helping children to process and practise what they know.

3.4.2. From Listening to Expression

The path from listening to speaking is gradual. It holds the same for L2. Learners may go through a silent period where they absorb the language before feeling ready to speak in it. During this phase, it's important that the teacher keeps providing input without pressuring the learners to respond. Patience is the key here.

Gradually, learners will at first respond in L1, followed by use of one-word responses, then short phrases, and eventually in full sentences in L2. It is important to encourage them to take risks and celebrate their little attempts to build their confidence.

Let's look into this more deeply with the help of an exemplary classroom practice.

Pedagogy and
Resources

Notes

Once, a donkey wanted to eat something sweet. He asked his friends for something sweet to eat. The Bear said- Have some honey. The Donkey refused. The Rabbit said- Have some carrots. The Donkey refused. The Ant said- Have some jaggery. The Donkey refused again. The Elephant said- Eat sugarcane. The Donkey said- NO! The Squirrel offered a mango. The Donkey refused. The Cat said- Let's go to the *mithai* shop. The Donkey loved the idea. They all started towards the *Mithai* shop.



Fig. 3.3: Mithai (Barkha Series, NCERT, 2022)

A teacher tells a simple story in English titled “Mithai.” The story is as follows:
The teacher asks simple questions related to prediction while reading the story.
Like:

Teacher: Who do you think will be the next animal?

Child 1: *Haathi!!*

Child 2: Lion!!

Teacher: What will the Cat offer to -the Donkey?

Child: Doodh!! Milk. She will give milk.

Teacher: Why?

Child: Cat drinks milk.

Teacher: What did the Donkey say?

Child: The Donkey refused.

Then the teacher asked the children to form groups and enact the story.

Here, the teacher tells a simple story in English with action, intonation, and visual aids.

- The children listened and responded to comprehension questions based on their previous knowledge and existing vocabulary, which is a mix of English and their home language.
- Some children repeat the key phrases from the story (e.g., “The Donkey Refused”)
- Later, they retell the story in their own words using a mix of English and their home language.



This process supports translanguageing, a strategy advocated and supported by NEP 2020 and NCF-FS 2022, which allows learners to move fluidly between languages as they acquire new skills.

Translanguageing is a versatile concept that characterises the ways in which bilingual or multilingual learners utilise their various languages. Learners seamlessly navigate between languages to engage with and comprehend their surroundings.

This practice proves particularly beneficial within language classrooms, where students may leverage their linguistic diversity to enhance their educational experience. For instance, a student might read in English while discussing or taking notes in their native language, or may incorporate elements of both languages in their work. Educators who embrace translanguageing may provide multilingual glossaries, encourage students to draft written assignments in their first languages, or facilitate discussions in any of the students' languages.

Ultimately, translanguageing acknowledges the interconnected nature of a learner's languages and aims to empower individuals by recognising and valuing the full array of their linguistic resources.

3.4.3. Strategies for Oral Language Development in a Second Language Classroom

This section will discuss about the strategies to enhance oral language development in L2. A teacher can use the following suggestive activities/methods to encourage the use of L2 in their classrooms.

- **Picture Talk:** Show a poster or picture in the classroom and ask the children to describe what they see and observe. Teachers can use prompting questions to coax responses from children. The questions should include closed-ended and open-ended questions. Scaffold their responses with prompts and gestures.
- **Storytelling and Retelling:** Use familiar stories, folk tales, or fables. Read them aloud in the class with appropriate aids and gestures. Encourage children to retell the story or its parts.
- **Drama and Role Play:** Give daily life situations like visiting a shop, buying fruits or vegetables, an argument between friends or siblings for them to act out. It could be in pairs or groups. They can also be given the task to enact their favourite story, part of the story, or their favourite character.

Pedagogy and
Resources

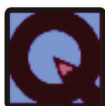
Notes

- **Language Games:** Games like “Guess the Object”, “King Says”, “Find Me”, or “Dumb Charades” promote vocabulary and oral language skills.
- **Conversation Corners:** Set up spaces for pair or group dialogue/ discussions/conversations using flashcards or sentence strips.
- **Question Circles:** Children sit in a circle and take turns asking and answering questions about a topic or situation related to the classroom.
- **Opinion and Feedback:** Invite children to say what they liked or did not like after a story session or a game, or any other activity. This gives them an opportunity to reflect and think about their thoughts and listen to and reflect on others, too.

3.4.4. The Teacher’s Role

In a second language classroom, the teacher plays a multifaceted role. They act as a facilitator, model, and supporter. A teacher should:

- **Encourage interaction:** Create pairs and groups for children to practise speaking with each other.
- **Accept code-switching, code-mixing, and translanguaging:** Accept when learners use their home language in English classrooms, thus allowing them to shift between their L1 and L2 to make sense of their learning and enhance their learning experience to be able to better express themselves.
- **Celebrate efforts and attempts:** Praise all attempts at speaking, even if incorrect. The goal is to encourage communication, not correctness.
- **Give space for expression:** Allow the child to say the whole thing without contradicting or cutting them in between. This gives them the confidence to express without feeling fear or anxiety.

**CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 3.3**

1. Why is oral language essential in the acquisition of a second language like English?
2. List three oral activities that help children develop speaking skills in L2.

3. How can a teacher support children during the “silent period” in L2 learning?

3.5 LISTENING AND SPEAKING: FOUNDATION FOR ORAL LANGUAGE DEVELOPMENT IN L2

When children enter school, they are engaged in lots of listening and speaking activities for the first few months before they are introduced to formal reading and writing practices. These activities can be in the form of songs, rhymes, poems, stories, games, instructions etc. These activities are done irrespective of languages and subjects. As primary teachers, we have also done this ourselves. This is done because we believe that a child should first learn to listen and speak a language before they can read and write it. In oral language development, both skills are equally important. They are parallel processes.

When we talk about oral language, we talk about both listening and speaking skills. Listening and speaking together make the foundation for oral language development. We all know that children learn to listen and speak, even before they learn to read and write. A child must be able to first hear and understand a language before they begin to use it in real situations. This holds equally true for L2. NEP 2020 and NCF-FS (2022) repeatedly emphasise that a child acquires a language easily and naturally when they are given the opportunity to listen, speak, play, and interact with the language in meaningful contexts. This is particularly true in the case of L2, as it is not the primary medium at home. It is therefore important that the development of listening and speaking skills in L2 should be intentional, engaging, and aligned with the developmental and linguistic readiness of the children.

Read the conversations given below between the teacher and her students. The teacher has just read a story to her students and is asking the students some questions.

Teacher: Who can tell me what happened to the little brown bear?

Rohan: I liked the brown bear.

Soumya: He wanted honey.

Lalita: He fell down. He wanted honey and climbed the tree, but he fell down.

From the conversation above, who do you think gave the right answer?

Yes, you are correct. It was Lalita. But why do you think Lalita was able to answer correctly? Let's break it down.



Notes

Pedagogy and
Resources

Notes

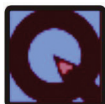
Lalita listened to the story, understood the character's actions, and the main events of the story. Her brain processed the information and made sense of it. She answered the teacher's question directly by retelling the part of the story. It showed that she understood what she heard, which allowed her to answer correctly. On the other hand, Rohan did not understand the purpose of the question, which was to recall the story or the content of the story itself, and said something entirely unrelated to the question despite speaking English.

Here, it is important to note that oral language (listening and speaking) is not just about hearing words and repeating them. It is about 'understanding' what those words mean, reflecting on them, and then responding back, so that you can communicate properly. Understanding is a crucial component for effective oral language development. Without understanding, communication breaks down into a mere series of sounds and noises. Even when we are speaking, we listen to ourselves. Even while watching TV, we are not merely consuming the sounds but absorbing what is being said. We listen to it, reflect on it, and keep it with us. During a conversation, we listen to the other person, understand what they are saying, and then respond to them.

The above example was an attempt to show that when children listen with understanding, they can speak in ways that make sense and show what they have learnt. The best example of this is the "talk" that takes place in the classroom among the students and between the students and the teacher.

So, these skills cannot be developed separately while learning a language. Both are mutually dependent skills wherein the process of understanding is interconnected, thus contributing to the oral language development of the child.

In the upcoming sections, we will be looking at some of the classroom strategies to enhance the oral language development of children in the context of L2, focusing on listening and speaking skills. Again, it is important to remember that both skills are mutually dependent on each other, with one taking a more dominant role over the other at times.

**CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 3.4**

1. What is a significant part of listening- speaking?
 - (a) listening
 - (b) speaking



(c) understanding

(d) memorising

2. What kind of opportunities are given to children to listen and speak, usually, in the earlier classes in schools? Are these opportunities sufficient? Give your opinion.
3. Why are listening and speaking mutually dependent on each other for oral language development?

Answer:

1. c). understanding

3.5.1. Listening in a Second Language

Listening is the gateway to second language acquisition and learning. Children gain exposure to the sound system, patterns, vocabulary, rhythm, grammar, and intonation of any language through listening. It helps them in comprehension, memory, and recognising the commonly used phrases and vocabulary of any language. Listening is a very common practice among people who are trying to learn a new language. They listen to songs, watch TV programs and movies, interviews to immerse themselves in the language experience to get familiar with the sound system, speech patterns, intonation, and vocabulary of the target language. Let us discuss some common classroom strategies that aim to enhance the listening skills of the child:

- **Storytelling:** Read stories aloud using intonation and gestures. Ask questions before, during, and after reading the stories to build and assess students' understanding of the story.
- **Songs and Rhymes:** Use simple rhymes in the beginning with repetitive words, such as “Twinkle Twinkle” or poems with gestures or action songs like “If you’re happy and you know it” for pattern recognition.
- **Listening Games:** “King/Simon Says” helps follow instructions, building attentiveness and understanding verbs or action words (e.g., *jump, touch, clap, etc.*). “Who am I?” involves the use of descriptive words that help students guess an object or person.
- **Audio clips and Videos:** Play audio stories, rhymes, read-along stories, songs, or cartoons or animated stories with subtitles to aid understanding.

Pedagogy and
Resources

Notes

It is crucial that teachers ensure that the listening materials used are not too fast or complex for the child. They should be appropriate as per the age and proficiency level of the child. Teachers can also pre-teach some vocabulary before using the audio aids to reinforce the learning when necessary. Repetition is essential when teaching L2 to reinforce understanding.

3.5.2 Speaking in a Second Language

Speaking is the most expressive form of oral language. It is important to create a safe, non-threatening, comfortable space for children to be able to express themselves openly. This becomes crucial in an L2 environment as they are unfamiliar with the language and are afraid of making mistakes, which makes them hesitant to speak. Creating an accepting atmosphere encourages risk-taking behaviour and makes attempts where they focus more on communication and expression than correctness of language. When a child is given ample exposure to L2 through listening materials and activities, eventually they will start imitating the language behaviour of L2 and begin using it in their communication.

Let's look at the different stages a child goes through during the development of speaking skills in L2:

1. Repeating of single words or one-word responses (e.g., “red”, “good”, “water”). This might include words they hear regularly in their daily context. This can be done in the form of rhymes, repeated instructions, common phrases they use, or through pictorial instructions.
2. Using a combination of two words (e.g., “want water”, “eat lunch”, “go toilet”) to express needs and desires.
3. Using simple sentences (e.g., “This is my book”, “I want to play”, “Can I draw?”)
4. Structured conversations with teachers and peers.

Let us discuss some common classroom strategies that aim to enhance the speaking skills of the child:

- **Daily Conversation Practice:** Using greeting words or phrases like “Good Morning”, “Good Afternoon”, or seeking permissions like “Can I drink water?”, “May I come in?” etc.
- **Morning Message /Today’s Talk/ Circle time:** Children share what



they did the day before, or what they plan to do today, or any event that happened every morning in the class with their teacher and peers, like “I went to a wedding last night”, “I bought a new book yesterday”. The teacher can write these on the board.

- **Show and Tell:** Teacher or children bring an object of their choice, or related to a particular theme or topic, and describe it using simple sentences.
- **Picture Talk:** Children describe a picture or poster based on their observation. The teacher can ask guiding and prompting questions like “What can you see?”, “What are they doing?” and the children respond.
- **Role Play:** Set up classroom scenarios - e.g., shopkeeper and customer, doctor and patient. They can use sentence prompts in case students are beginners, or develop their own dialogues in case they are older.
- **Drama and Skits:** Short scenes with familiar stories or settings can be done (e.g., birthday party, zoo visit, market, exhibition, fair) to help in the contextual usage of vocabulary.
- **Acting out:** Children are given prompts (could be an action, situation) and they need to act them out, and other students try to guess or describe what the child is doing.

Even though the activities might predominantly focus on one skill over the other, it cannot be denied that listening and speaking are simultaneously working together to aid oral language development in L2. In real communication, listening and speaking are inseparable. Group activities, pair work, and circle time should include opportunities for both. For Example:

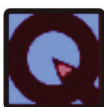
- **Peer Interview:** Children can either work in pairs or groups and take turns asking each other questions like, “What is your name?”, “What do you like?”, “How old are you?” and answer.
- **Sound Hunt:** Play sounds of animals or objects. Children will try to guess and respond (e.g., “It is an elephant”). Then, they describe the animal or object in one or two sentences. This builds upon their previous knowledge of sound and usage of descriptive words to describe the animals.
- **Draw this:** Students work in pairs or small groups. One student

Pedagogy and
Resources

Notes

describes a simple drawing or object (e.g., “Draw a big circle. Then, draw a small triangle inside it”), and the other students draw and, in cases, ask clarifying questions. It involves giving clear, precise instructions using descriptive vocabulary and following and interpreting instructions carefully.

- **Story chain:** The teacher starts a story with one sentence, and each child in the circle adds one sentence to continue and build the story. It requires children to listen to make meaningful additions and speak clearly for the next person to hear and understand.

**CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 3.5**

1. What is the role of a teacher as a listener in an oral language classroom?
2. Mention three classroom activities that can support the development of speaking skills in L2.
3. How can you, as a teacher, scaffold children’s responses in L2? List three strategies based on your understanding.

3.6 INCLUSIVE CLASSROOM PRACTICES FOR ORAL LANGUAGE DEVELOPMENT

NEP (2020), NCF-FS (2022), and NCF-SE (2023) all recommend that a child’s learning must begin in their home language or mother tongue and that the transition to a second language should be a gradual, meaningful process supported by contextually rich oral input.

In multilingual classrooms, especially in India, children, when they enter a classroom, carry with them a rich linguistic background rooted in their home language/ mother tongue/ first language. A second language (L2) is often introduced in a school context. Most of the time, L2 is a language that is not spoken at home. In such scenarios, inclusive classroom practices become essential to ensure that every child has the opportunity to participate, learn, and express in L2 without fear or pressure. But what do we mean by inclusive classroom practices? Let us discuss with the help of an example.

In a primary classroom in Assam, the teacher shows a picture of a village market and asks the children to describe what they see in English. One child says, “I see one man fish *bikoi ase*.” The teacher smiles and responds, “Very good! You are right. I see one man selling fish. ”



What did the teacher do here? She used the moment to model English while respecting the child's comfort and language, putting emphasis on communication instead of the correctness of the answer.

Inclusive classroom practices in the context of oral language development refer to a set of teaching approaches that ensure that all learners, irrespective of their linguistic, cultural, or social backgrounds, have equal opportunities to participate. These practices become even more critical in the context of L2. These practices recognise this diversity as a strength rather than a barrier and use it to create a classroom environment where every child feels free, is seen, heard, and encouraged to use language confidently.

As discussed, many times in the previous sections, Oral language is not simply about correct pronunciation or vocabulary recall in L2. It focuses on enabling children to make meaning, ask questions, describe their experiences, and interact with others. In an L2 classroom, it means moving beyond traditional rote-based learning models and fostering real communication through meaningful and engaging activities. An inclusive classroom allows children to engage in listening and speaking as a part of broader learning experiences.

These experiences may arise in a variety of contexts across the curriculum, like observing nature, solving problems, narrating personal stories, participating in class projects, or discussing daily routines, thus providing natural and authentic learning platforms for oral expression.

The teacher's role here is to provide the children with these flexible and interdisciplinary learning scenarios, where they can talk about what they observe, draw, count, compare, and explore. Though the central focus during oral language learning should remain on speaking and listening, involving reference to written texts, labelling, identifying objects, or writing brief responses is also important. As a result, children began to see L2 as a tool that they can use across different contexts. Let us look at some activities and strategies that teachers can use to incorporate inclusiveness in classrooms.

(i) Picture Talk with Word Labelling

Show a thematic poster or a picture (e.g., market, fair, shop, railway station, etc.) in the classroom and give a print version of it to the students in the form of a worksheet to children and initiate a discussion using prompts like – “What do you see?”, “What are the people doing?”, “What place is this?”. Listen to children's responses, such as objects, places, or actions, write them on the board,

Pedagogy and
Resources

Notes

and ask them to write the same in their worksheets. They can label objects or actions. Children can read them aloud and repeat after the teacher. Welcome responses from the child's home language.

This activity incorporates the use of reading and writing skills along with oral language and can be done in both language and EVS classrooms.

(ii) Number Talk

Use a rhyme with numbers like 'Two Little Hands' for NCERT *Mridang* – class 1 or 'Ten Little Fingers'. Read the poem aloud with actions and gestures. Later, show number cards and ask, "How many _____ are there?", "Can you count and say?". Let children answer using complete sentences.

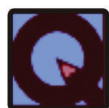
The activity cuts across mathematics, EVS, and language. The teacher can extend the oral task by providing a worksheet with images to count and colour, and encourage them to copy simple number names.

(iii) Role Play with Shopping or Daily Routine

Set up a "market corner" in the class. Use real or pretend fruits, vegetables, and money notes. Assign roles like shopkeeper and customer to children. Children can practise dialogues like, "I want two bananas", "What is the price of cauliflower?", etc. Ask the shopkeeper to label items and their prices. For children in preparatory classes, the complexity can be increased by asking the shopkeepers to make bills for purchases by customers.



Fig. 3.4: Role Play with Shopping or Daily Routine
(Mridang I, NCERT, 2024, p. 4)



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 3.6

1. Why is it important to use children's home language in L2 classrooms?
2. How can reading or writing be included in support of oral language development in L2? Write one activity.
3. List two ways teacher can promote inclusive oral language practices in classroom.



3.7. LET US SUM UP

- Oral language development is foundational for acquiring a second language and must be nurtured through meaningful and inclusive interactions in the classroom.
- The Four-Block Approach offers a balanced framework for literacy that integrates oral language, word recognition, reading comprehension, and writing.
- Children acquire language most effectively when given opportunities to listen, speak, observe, and participate in real-life, interactive experiences.
- Listening and speaking are interdependent processes that support cognitive development and language learning; they cannot be separated from comprehension and expression.
- Inclusive classroom practices respect children's home languages and use them as a bridge to help them transition into a second language.
- Oral language learning should be integrated with reading and writing in contextually rich tasks that reflect everyday life and cross-disciplinary learning.
- Activities such as storytelling, picture description, drama, and role play help learners construct meaning and gain confidence in using a second language.
- Code-mixing and translanguaging are valuable tools in early L2 instruction and should be accepted as part of the natural learning process.
- Teachers play a central role in modelling language, scaffolding



Notes



Notes

responses, and encouraging risk-free participation in second language communication.



3.8. UNIT END EXERCISES

1. Why is it important to allow the use of home language in early L2 learning?
2. Mention any two classroom strategies to support learners during the silent period.
3. Explain the Four-Block Approach and its relevance in developing oral language in L2.
4. Describe any four inclusive classroom activities that can help build oral language skills among primary class students in L2.
5. Designing an activity for L2 incorporating all four blocks.
6. Reflect on the challenges you may face while in second language oral development. Suggest methods on how you will try to resolve them.

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